Spare Our Religion

Development challenges are huge in a country like ours but if political parties are committed, sustained growth is possible," says Zeenathar Azmi Syed, a sociologist passionate about development studies. The youngest of three siblings of a physician and a former member of the Telangana State Legal Services Authority, she feels that schemes like Viksit Bharat, Ujjwala and Lakhpati Didi are well intentioned. "As a woman, I find these initiatives important for our welfare, but the challenge lies in the execution," she says.

Azmi says a key issue will determine her vote. "If a candidate explicitly or implicitly expresses that religious convictions will control how he or she governs, then that person is not getting my vote. Note that I refer to control rather than practice." On how life has changed in the past decade, Azmi explains how she cracked the UGC-NET exam, got into the PhD programme and was in the merit list of the UGC's Maulana Azad National Fellowship, a scheme beneficial for her research. The scheme was revoked in 2022. ■

-Amarnath K. Menon



Zeenathfar Azmi Syed, *29*

Hyderabad

Research scholar at Osmania University, social activist

Constituency: Secunderabad

Issues that will decide her vote: Family, community opinion will matter

Demands from the govt: Accessible quality education, a public funded healthcare system for all; and an annual job calendar

welfare schemes, has eluded her despite several appeals to the village head. "Many people in my village get free ration and have benefitted from the PM Awas Yojana whereas we have been unlucky. Why would we praise the government?" asks Suman, the wife of a farm labourer.

She believes Prime Minister Narendra Modi has done a lot of good work but it hasn't reached everyone. "There are several loopholes at the implementation stages," says Suman, who has studied till Class V. "More than the Ram temple, we need basic infrastructure for the poor. We do not have money and power, so no one comes to help us," says the Dalit woman. ■

"More than the Ram temple, we need basic infrastructure for the poor"

-Prashant Srivastava



MANDAR DEODHAR

Back to Firewood

Tai Balu Kasbe, *42*

Pune, *Domestic help*

Constituency: Pune

Issues that will decide her vote: Soaring prices of essential commodities

Demands from the govt: Reduce inflation, LPG prices

The resident of Sahakar Nagar in Pune city works as a housemaid in the local highrises, while her husband Balu Jangli Kasbe is a rickshaw driver. Kasbe, a Dalit from the Matang community, complains that the couple (they have no children) can barely make ends meet with their monthly income of around Rs 25,000.

"Everything is so costly, prices are soaring and all my women friends are very upset. I have been forced to put our gas cylinder away and cook using firewood and cowdung cakes," she rues. "Even when we buy things like clothes, we have to pay extra for GST. What can the poor do, we are badly affected by inflation. This is not a good government for us," says Kasbe. She feels that issues like the Ram temple in Ayodhya, and even the Centre's welfare schemes, are of no consequence because of this. "What is the use of the Ujjwala scheme if you can no longer afford an LPG cylinder?" she asks. ■

-Dhaval S. Kulkarni